

STUDY SHEET - BLOCK 4: CHAPTER FOUR (The Second Spirit)

1. Plot (Trama)

Scrooge wakes up and sees a strong light coming from the next room [cite: 4]. He enters and finds the Second Spirit, the Ghost of Christmas Present. The Ghost is a joyful giant surrounded by a massive amount of delicious Christmas food and holding a torch [cite: 4]. Scrooge touches the Spirit's clothes and they are instantly transported to the snowy city streets on Christmas morning [cite: 4].

It is a busy, cheerful scene with bells ringing [cite: 4]. They see poor people happily carrying their Christmas dinners (goose or chicken) to the baker's shops to be cooked in the ovens [cite: 4]. The Spirit uses his torch to sprinkle a blessing on their food.

The Spirit then takes Scrooge to the humble home of his clerk, **Bob Cratchit**. Despite their poverty, the family is incredibly happy and united. Bob arrives carrying his sick and crippled son, **Tiny Tim**, on his shoulder [cite: 4]. Mrs Cratchit and the children (like Belinda) prepare the table [cite: 4]. They share a small dinner (a goose and a Christmas pudding), but they are extremely grateful [cite: 4]. Scrooge is deeply moved by Tiny Tim's frailty and begs the Spirit to tell him if the boy will live [cite: 4]. The Spirit uses Scrooge's own cruel words against him, saying that if he dies, it will "decrease the surplus population".

Later, they visit the cheerful home of Scrooge's nephew, Fred, where everyone is playing games and having fun. Fred says he feels sorry for Scrooge, who is the only one missing out on the joy of Christmas. At the end of the chapter, the Spirit shows Scrooge two terrifying, starving children hiding under his robe: *Ignorance* and *Want* (Ignoranza e Bisogno), warning Scrooge to beware of them.

2. Characters (Personaggi)

- **The Ghost of Christmas Present (The Second Spirit):** A majestic, generous giant wearing a green robe. He represents joy, abundance, and the generosity of the Christmas spirit. He lives only for one day (Christmas Day).
- **Bob Cratchit and his family:** They represent the working poor. Despite having very little money and struggling to survive, they are full of love. Mrs Cratchit, Belinda, and the others work together to make the day special [cite: 4].
- **Tiny Tim:** Bob's youngest son. He is severely disabled and walks with a crutch. He is

incredibly sweet and pure. His situation awakens Scrooge's empathy for the first time.

- **Ignorance and Want:** Two monstrous children representing the terrible conditions of the poor in Victorian society, caused by humanity's selfishness.

3. Themes (Tematiche)

- **The True Christmas Spirit:** Seen through the Cratchits and Fred, showing that joy comes from family and love, not from money.
- **Empathy and Compassion:** For the first time, Scrooge feels genuine concern for another human being when he asks if Tiny Tim will live [cite: 4]. This is a crucial step in his redemption.
- **Poverty and Social Responsibility:** The Cratchits are poor, but they have dignity. However, the presence of the children "Ignorance" and "Want" is a strong critique by Dickens against a society that abandons its most vulnerable people.

4. Useful Vocabulary (Vocabolario utile)

- **Torch:** Torcia (il fantasma la usa per benedire il cibo [cite: 4])
- **Cheerful:** Allegro (riferito all'atmosfera nelle strade [cite: 4])
- **Baker's shop:** Forno / Panetteria (dove i poveri cuocevano la cena [cite: 4])
- **Goose / Christmas pudding:** Oca / Budino di Natale (il tipico pasto natalizio [cite: 4])
- **Crutch:** Stampella
- **To carry on his shoulder:** Portare sulle spalle (Bob porta così Tiny Tim [cite: 4])
- **Ignorance and Want:** Ignoranza e Bisogno/Indigenza

5. Possible Questions & Short Answers (Domande per la verifica)

- **Q1: How does Scrooge find the Second Spirit?**
Answer: He sees a strong light coming from the next room and finds a giant spirit surrounded by food [cite: 4].
- **Q2: Where did the poor people take their Christmas dinners to be cooked?**
Answer: They took their goose or chicken to the baker's shops to be cooked in the ovens [cite: 4].
- **Q3: Who is Tiny Tim and how does his father bring him home?**
Answer: Tiny Tim is Bob Cratchit's sick and crippled son. Bob carries him home on his shoulder [cite: 4].

- **Q4: How does Scrooge react when he sees Tiny Tim?**

Answer: He is deeply touched and worried. He asks the Spirit, "Say he will live!" [cite: 4].